

SBIR First-Timer's Handbook

Worksheet Pack

Companion to the book 'The SBIR First-Timer's Handbook: From the NSF Project Pitch to a Phase I award'.

This is a private study aid. It is not a government form, and filling it in does not register, pitch, or submit anything.

A Project Pitch needs no registrations. SAM.gov registration is free. FAST, SBDC and APEX Accelerator help is free. Nobody needs to charge you to apply, and NSF has said it will never ask you to share personal or sensitive award information with a third party.

These are the fill-in tools from the book, on paper. Each one matches a chapter or appendix, and the chapter explains why the worksheet asks what it asks.

Free to copy. FAST organizations, SBDC and APEX Accelerator counselors, university technology-transfer offices, and any business-assistance organization may reproduce and distribute this pack for client use without asking.

What is in here

0. The whole path on one page, and which reader you are
1. The registrations at a glance, and the pre-flight checklist
2. The Project Pitch worksheet - four fields, in characters
3. NSF Phase I proposal checklist
4. Defense Phase I proposal checklist
5. Your Phase I budget - every line and its rule
6. Free help - who to ask for what, and your contacts
7. Is this from the government? - four questions, in order
8. A log to keep - from the first pitch to the final report

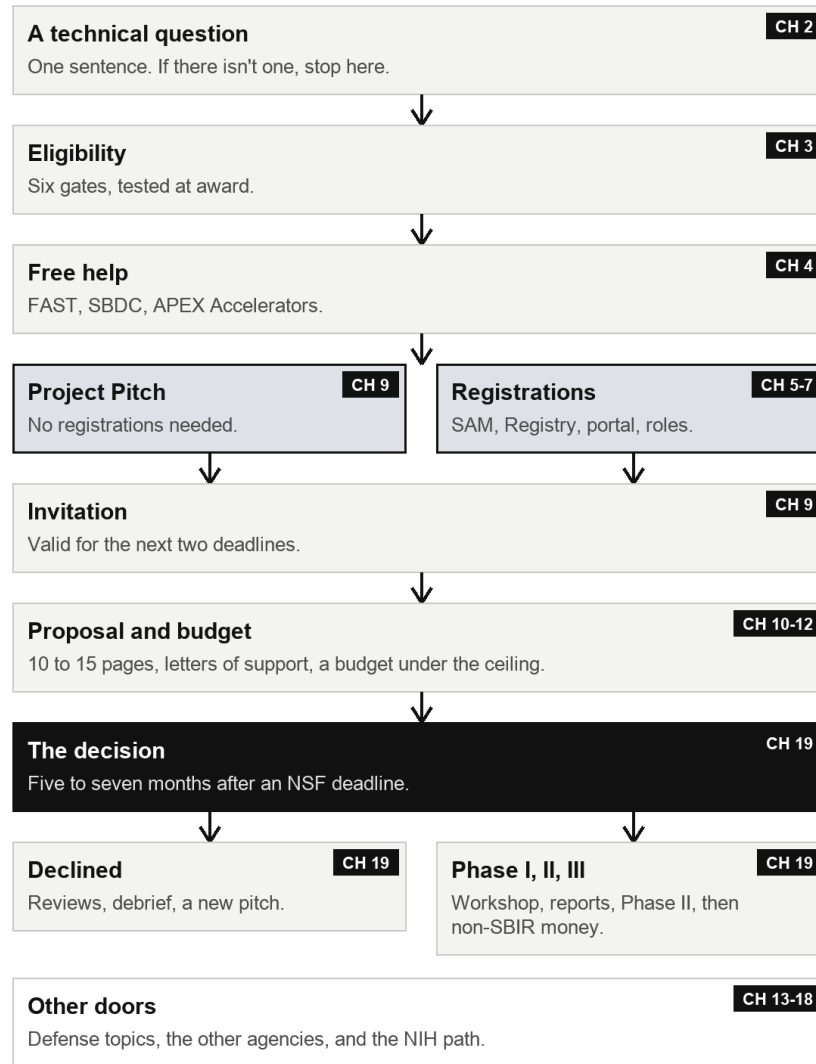
Rules change. Check the date on the book's copyright page, and the book's links page, before relying on anything here.

0. The whole path on one page

From an idea to Phase III, with the chapter for each step. Pin it up.

THE WHOLE PATH ON ONE PAGE

From an idea to Phase III, with the chapters that cover each step.



SBIR is non-dilutive: grants or contracts, never a share of the company.
SAM.gov registration is free.

Which reader are you?

If you are...	Start with
An idea and nothing else yet	Chapter 2 tonight, then Chapter 3; then the pitch (Ch 9) and the registrations (Ch 5) the same week
Invited to submit an NSF proposal	Chapter 7 first, to be sure you can press submit, then Part III
A university researcher looking at STTR	Chapter 3's work-share rules, Chapter 14's STTR section, Chapter 4
Doing the registrations for a founder	Part II and Appendix A
Applying to NIH	Part V (Chapters 15 to 18), then Chapter 7 for eRA Commons and Grants.gov
Answering a Defense topic	Chapter 13, then Chapter 3, then Chapter 8
Declined once	Chapter 19, then Chapter 2 again
Awarded	Chapter 19's second half and Chapter 12's data rights
A counselor	Chapter 2 and Appendix H

1. The registrations at a glance

Bottom to top. Each needs what the one before it gives. Estimates are the agencies' own, as read in September 2026.

Registration	Needs first	Gives you	Agency estimate
Company formed	-	Legal name and address	Varies by state
EIN (IRS)	The company	Taxpayer ID	Up to 2 weeks to show in SAM's check
Business bank account	EIN	Account and routing number	Varies
SAM.gov	The above	UEI, then CAGE when Active	10 business days to a month
SBA Company Registry	UEI only	SBC Control ID, proof PDF	1 to 2 business days (NIH)
Research.gov (NSF)	UEI	Administrator, PI, AOR roles	Not stated
eRA Commons (NIH)	UEI; full SAM by submission	Signing Official, PD/PI	Two weeks or more
Grants.gov (NIH)	Active SAM	AOR role from the EBiz POC	One business day or more
DSIP (Defense)	A Login.gov account each	Firm Admin, proposal access	As soon as possible

Not on the ladder: the Project Pitch. NSF requires none of these to submit one.

Pre-flight checklist

- ☐ The legal name and address are written once, on one page, and pasted identically everywhere.
- ☐ SAM shows Active, and the renewal date is on the calendar.
- ☐ The SAM registration purpose covers the award type (All Awards if Defense is possible).
- ☐ The Company Registry email matches a contact in SAM.
- ☐ The SBC Control ID is written down and the proof PDF is saved with the proposal.
- ☐ Your portal role can submit: AOR in Research.gov or Grants.gov, or a DSIP user on the proposal.
- ☐ A second person can reach the accounts on deadline day.
- ☐ The ownership answers agree in the Registry, SAM, and the proposal forms.

Your numbers

UEI	
CAGE code	
SBC Control ID	
SAM renewal date	
Portal and role	

2. The Project Pitch worksheet

Limits are in characters, spaces included. Paste each draft into a character counter before you submit. This uses one of your two pitches for the next twelve months.

1. The Technology Innovation (3,500 characters)

Answer: What's the high-risk innovation, what R&D does it need, and how is it significantly better than what exists?

Check: Does any sentence describe a feature or benefit instead of the innovation?

2. Technical Objectives and Challenges (3,500 characters)

Answer: What R&D proves the technology works? For each objective, what's the challenge and how will you manage it?

Check: Can each objective be answered with a number? Would these tasks fit anyone else's pitch?

3. The Market Opportunity (1,750 characters)

Answer: Who's the customer, what does the innovation do for them, and why could it compete?

Check: Is the customer a buyer with a budget, not 'the market'? Are real alternatives named?

4. The Company and Team (1,750 characters)

Answer: Why can this team do the research, and how will the gaps be filled?

Check: Is there a gap you haven't mentioned that a reviewer would notice?

3. NSF Phase I proposal checklist

In Research.gov order, per NSF 26-510 and NSF's instructions as read in September 2026.

- ☐ Cover Sheet, SBIR/STTR Questionnaire, and Certification Questions (filled in completely)
- ☐ Project Summary: one page; Overview, Intellectual Merit, Broader Impacts headings on their own lines
- ☐ Project Description: 10 to 15 pages; four required headers; no URLs
- ☐ References Cited, or 'no references cited'
- ☐ Budget: \$305,000 maximum including the fee and TABA; no equipment
- ☐ Budget Justification: five pages maximum; every nonzero line by code
- ☐ Facilities, Equipment and Other Resources (signed statement for anything not owned or leased)
- ☐ Biographical Sketch in SciENCv, for each senior or key person
- ☐ Current and Pending (Other) Support in SciENCv, listing this proposal as pending
- ☐ Collaborators and Other Affiliations, on NSF's template
- ☐ Synergistic Activities, one page each
- ☐ Data Management and Sharing Plan (checkbox and the proprietary statement)
- ☐ Mentoring Plan, only if a subaward pays postdocs or graduate students
- ☐ Letters of Support: at least one, no more than three, from stakeholders, with contact information
- ☐ Letters of Commitment from subawardees and consultants
- ☐ IP Rights Agreement (required for STTR; draft acceptable)
- ☐ Resubmission Change Description, only for a revised proposal
- ☐ The Project Pitch invitation email, as a PDF
- ☐ Submitted by the AOR, by 5 p.m. your local time

4. Defense Phase I proposal checklist

Seven volumes in DSIP. DSIP accepting an upload doesn't check the component's own rules.

- ☐ Volume 1: Proposal Cover Sheet
- ☐ Volume 2: Technical Volume, within the component's page limit (Navy Phase I: 10 pages)
- ☐ Volume 3: Cost Volume on DSIP's form; key personnel hours; any option costed separately
- ☐ Volume 4: Company Commercialization Report, from SBIR.gov, uploaded by the Firm Admin
- ☐ Volume 5: Supporting Documents the component allows, including the Company Registry proof
- ☐ Volume 6: Fraud, Waste and Abuse Training (required for submission)
- ☐ Volume 7: Disclosures of Foreign Affiliations or Relationships to Foreign Countries
- ☐ The component-specific instructions read in full
- ☐ Questions asked in pre-release, or in Topic Q&A before it closes (two weeks before topic close)

This topic

Topic number	
Component	
Pre-release / open / close	
Page limit	
Phase I ceiling	

5. Your NSF Phase I budget

Each line's rule, from NSF's budget instructions. Fill in the right-hand column.

Line	What goes here	Rule	Amount
A	Senior/key personnel	PI at least 1 calendar month per 6 months	
B	Other personnel	Company employees only	
C	Fringe benefits	Only if your accounting treats fringe as direct	
D	Equipment	Not allowed on a Phase I grant	\$0
E	Travel	R&D only, plus I-Corps; no foreign travel	
F	Participant support	Not permitted	\$0
G.1	Materials and supplies	Items under \$5,000	
G.2	Publication costs	Not allowed	\$0
G.3	Consultants	Up to \$1,000 per 8-hour day; letter of commitment	
G.4	Computer services	Itemize	
G.5	Subawards	Own budget and justification; no fee	
G.6	Other direct	Services; accounting up to \$10,000; I-Corps up to \$25,000; TABA up to \$6,500	
	Total direct		
I	Indirect	Negotiated rate, or up to 50% of salaries and wages, or 15% de minimis on MTDC	
J	Total direct and indirect		
K	Fee	Up to 7% of Line J	
	Total request	\$305,000 maximum	

- ☐ Total request is \$305,000 or less.
- ☐ Subawards plus consultants are no more than one-third of the budget (SBIR).
- ☐ Every nonzero line is in the justification, which is five pages or fewer.

6. Free help

You need	Ask	Where
A read of your pitch or proposal; possibly Phase 0 money	Your state's FAST organization	sbir.gov/community/fast
The market section, business plan, or budget	A Small Business Development Center	americassbdc.org
A Defense topic, a contract, or SAM.gov	An APEX Accelerator	apexaccelerators.us
A university partner for STTR	Technology-transfer office	The university's website
Whether your idea fits NSF	NSF SBIR program	sbir@nsf.gov , 703-292-8050
A debrief after an NSF decision	Your NSF program director	Named in your decision notice
Research.gov technical help	Research.gov Help Desk	1-800-673-6188, rgov@nsf.gov

Your contacts

Organization	Person	Email or phone	Date contacted
FAST			
SBDC			
APEX Accelerator			
University partner			
NSF program director			

7. Is this from the government?

Ask these in order about any message that offers to help with a registration, a pitch, a report, or an award.

Did it come to you, rather than you going to it? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Does it say the agency sent it, or found you through your award? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Does it ask for personal or award information? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Does it ask you to pay to register, renew, or activate anything? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Any yes is a reason to stop and check. NSF: 'NSF will never ask you to share with any third-party entity your personal or other sensitive award-related information.'

What to do

- ☐ Don't respond. For NSF, forward it to your program director.
- ☐ Defense matters: the Defense Hotline, (800) 424-9098, or hotline@dodig.mil.
- ☐ HHS and NIH matters: the HHS Office of Inspector General, through its website.
- ☐ Go to the system yourself: type the address, sign in, and look.

8. A log to keep

Step	Date	Notes
Technical question written		
FAST or SBDC contacted		
Project Pitch submitted		
Pitch reply received		
SAM.gov started		
UEI issued		
Company Registry done		
Portal roles set up		
Letters of support requested		
Letters received		
Proposal submitted		
Decision received		
Debrief held		

If awarded

Step	Date	Notes
Award start		
Phase I Workshop		
TABA use approved		
Phase II window opens (6 months)		
Award end		
Final report due (15 days after end)		
Outcomes report submitted		
Phase II window closes (24 months)		
SAM renewal		
Next pitch available		